

L0 to L5: The Self-Driving Organization Ladder

FLOODGATE

Six levels of organizational autonomy across four questions: [What can AI see?](#) [What can AI do?](#) [Who can extend the system?](#) [How has the org changed?](#)

	L0	L1	L2	L3	L4	L5
	 AI AS THEATER Nothing meaningful is happening.	 PERSONAL PRODUCTIVITY AI helps individuals, not the company.	 TEAM WORKFLOW AI workflows live within team boundaries.	 ORGANIZATIONAL INFRASTRUCTURE AI acts across systems within bounds.	 COMPOUNDING OPERATING SYSTEM The system learns, decides, and scales improvement.	 VIRTUALLY SELF-DRIVING ORGANIZATION Core loops run autonomously. Humans steer strategy.
 What can AI see?	Nothing structured. Knowledge lives in people's heads and tools AI can't read.	Each individual's AI sees only what that person feeds it. No org-level visibility.	Teams have shared context. AI sees within team boundaries.	The whole org is queryable. Core systems of record exposed via APIs / MCP.	Sees relationships between what happens. Capture + synthesis + query are continuous.	Generative. The system asks its own questions, identifies gaps, proposes investigations and runs them.
 What can AI do?	Nothing of consequence. Maybe summarize a meeting if a human pastes the transcript.	Help individuals draft, summarize, brainstorm, code. No action on systems of record.	Functional workflows. Bounded actions within a team's domain.	Agents act across systems: update CRMs, open PRs, route tickets, run analyses.	Policy-driven decision authority within scoped domains. System improves itself.	Delegated authority for novel decisions. Acts, learns and escalates appropriately. Updates shared memory.
 Who can extend the system?	No one. AI is a personal tool, ungoverned and unintegrated.	Each user reinvents independently. Power users are heroes; their workflows leave.	Within a team, non-engineers tap into shared workflows. Across teams, not really.	Non-engineers author and share skills. Wins propagate across functions.	Non-engineers ship production tools. Hierarchy collapses to "channel managers".	Anyone can extend the system or product itself. Boundary between "internal tool" and product dissolves.
 How has the org changed?	It hasn't. Same chart, same handoffs, same dependence on managers as routers.	It hasn't. Same chart. Maybe a "Head of AI" hire and some AI products purchased.	Functional efficiency within roles. Hiring slows but org shape and role boundaries intact.	Org chart looks materially different vs. 2023. New archetypes. Token-maxing over headcount-maxing.	Customer signal-to-ship in hours. New incentives. AI proficiency tied to compensation.	Org self-modifies or proposes changes. Onboarding is system-driven. Knowledge lives in the system.



HARD TEST FOR EVERY LEVEL: Can AI complete any recurring business process end-to-end at this level?

COMMON FALSE POSITIVE: Announcements, dashboards, or AI use claims that don't reflect real autonomy.



Ann Miura-Ko
ann@floodgate.com